

More importantly, it accepts that what is good for the environment can also be good for development."

India has made it clear that it would make no concession in its agendas of poverty alleviation and economic development. But in the action plan, there is now a conscious decision to shift towards renewable forms of energy like solar, wind and nuclear to meet its burgeoning energy needs. That is critical because currently India is highly dependent on fossil fuels for its energy requirements. Coal remains the dominant fuel in India's energy mix with a share of 31 per cent. Petroleum products like oil and natural gas account for another 27 per cent. With oil prices galloping, India's import bill has shot up and has contributed to much of the current bout of inflation.

In power generation, thermal or coal-based power meet as much as 61 per cent of the demand followed by hydro which is around 24 per cent. Gas-fired power plants have grown in recent years and now account for 6 per cent. Wind and solar power account for around 7 per cent. Nuclear power accounts for only 3 per cent of the total. A major focus on renewable energies especially solar and wind would do much to reduce India's dependence on fossil fuels, lower its import bill and also provide a buffer from the vagaries of oil prices. The Government would have to work swiftly to offer the industry major financial incentives and cheap funding to popularise solar and wind energy, apart from other energy-efficient technologies. Tarun Das, chief mentor of the Confederation of Indian Industry, says: "Indian industry is committed to moving towards reducing energy consumption and a low carbon economy and we look forward to working with the government to do so."

Across the world there has been a major revival of nuclear power as a clean energy alternative. Countries like France now meet over 70 per cent of their electricity demand through nuclear power, substantially reducing their carbon emissions. If the Indo-US civil nuclear agreement comes through, it would give this form of power generation the much-needed boost.

I Push for polio drop-type of technology

For developing countries to voluntarily check their emission levels, the crux is securing clean technology and finance. There are several promising technologies being developed that could make a dramatic difference in energy saving. These include cars that run on hydrogen as fuel, large solar power plants, carbon capture and sequestration technology and even everyday items such as energy-efficient light bulbs. India should join other countries in

identifying several such critical technologies and push for making them available universally at low prices. The best example of such a global effort was when polio drops were distributed at a subsidised price across the world. That saw most countries being able to afford it in their national health programmes and resulted in almost eradicating polio from the globe.

India should also push for undertaking joint R&D with other countries to develop clean technologies. Importantly, developed countries must be willing to finance such ventures and channelise funds through UN agencies rather than making it donor-driven. Nitin Desai, former UN under secretary general for climate change, says: "We must insist

that these countries put the money on the table and make meaningful pledges. The real issue now is not so much command over oil but command over clean technology."



1% of India's land area for solar power could meet all its electricity needs

605 million tonne emissions can be reduced if fuel efficiency is improved

10,000 MW of power would be saved if CFLs were used for lighting homes in India

1.5 million tonne of steel can be recovered yearly through recycling

I Clean up your own act

Mahatma Gandhi once famously said: "The earth has enough resources to meet the needs of people but will never have enough to serve their greed." Individuals too can make a major contribution towards reducing India's overall emissions and saving the earth by reducing conspicuous consumption and adopting green measures. It could be as simple as using less air-conditioners, by wearing more comfortable Indian clothes like the lungi even to formal dos. Turning off computers and water heaters when not in use or switching to energy saving compact fluorescent lamps (CFLs) at

home. It could even be telecommuting to get business done rather than driving down or flying out to meet someone. Planning your grocery shopping so that you don't have to drive down again to buy salt. Insisting on green labels while you buy household devices such as refrigerators to ensure that these are energy efficient.

There is so much that each one of us could do. As Nobel laureate Al Gore, speaking at the INDIA TODAY Conclave in March this year, so stirringly put it: "We are one people. We live in separate nation states. We are proud of our differences and we will feel pride in our nations and in our different creed and beliefs. But ultimately we are one people on one planet. This is our home. It is endangered. Now is the time. This is the place. And we are the people who must accept this challenge. This generation today must become a hero generation. It will not be easy. It will be hard. Not rising to this challenge would be much harder still. I believe that we should see the opportunity, rise to meet it and keep our sights on the obligation that we have for those who come after. So that a thousand years from now people will say, they were the ones who did it."